LLM4S

VIPS 25 YEARS IN SERVICE OF HUMANITY

TECHNICAL SESSION

LLM4S Foundation: A Retrospective

FRI 23 OCTOBER 2026 | 10 AM ONWARDS

VENUE: VIPS-TC, SEMINAR HALL (Block C)



KANNUPRIYA KALRA
Co-Founder, LLM4S Foundation

OUR MISSION

Learn AI by building AI.

llm4s.org

OUR MISSION

LLM4S

Learn AI by building AI.

Empowering developers through hands-on GenAI projects, open-source contribution and responsible AI education.

400+	50	15	Free
COMMUNITY MEMBERS	MENTORS	LOCAL CHAPTERS	TO JOIN

ABOUT THE SPEAKER

Kannupriya Kalra

Co-Founder, LLM4S Foundation · London · linkedin.com/in/kannupriyakalra

CREATOR	LLM4S, an AI-native platform for Scala and the JVM
OPEN SOURCE	Contributes to AI and Scala through the Scala Center and Google Open Source
GSOC	Led the Scala Center's Google Summer of Code programmes in 2024 and 2025
AUTHOR	Four AI courses with Manning Publications, New York
SPEAKER	AI, Scala and open source in more than ten countries
ENGINEER	Built scalable backend systems in functional Scala at Sky, London



With Martin Odersky, creator of Scala, at Scala Days 2025 in Lausanne, discussing LLM4S

WHY THIS TALK

How to become an AI engineer through open source

LLM4S is an AI non-profit that gives you real-world, corporate-style experience for your resume, free of charge.

01 **Your edge**
Open source, your portfolio, and how to start

02 **The LLM4S story**
From one commit to a global community

03 **The lessons**
Five lessons for anyone building in public

04 **Your turn**
What you can do this week

05 **For founders**
Open source as a launchpad for your startup

FIRST COMMIT

29 Jan 2025

LATEST RELEASE

v0.5.1, 15 Oct 2026

NEXT

1.0

Words you'll hear today

Open source

Code anyone can read, use and improve

Like: *a recipe published for everyone to cook and improve*

GitHub

The website where code projects live

Like: *Google Drive for code, with every change saved*

Commit

One saved change, with a note

Like: *saving a version of your assignment*

Pull request

A proposed change, sent to be checked

Like: *suggesting mode in a shared Google Doc*

Code review

An experienced person checks your change

Like: *a teacher marking work before it goes on the board*

Maintainer

Someone who looks after a project

Like: *a magazine editor deciding what gets printed*

Scrum call

A short team check-in: done, next, blocked

Like: *a cricket team's huddle between overs*

LLM

The kind of AI behind ChatGPT

Like: *your phone's autocomplete, hugely scaled up*

What is open source, and why does it matter?

Software whose code anyone can read, use, change and share, under a licence that says so.



Read it

Every line is public, so you learn how real systems are built



Use it

Free to use, including at work and in your own products



Change it

Adapt it to your needs, or fix what is broken



Share it

Send your improvements back, and your name goes with them

YOU ALREADY USE IT EVERY DAY

Android
your phone

Linux
most of the internet's servers

Python
the language of AI

PyTorch
training AI models

Kubernetes
running cloud apps

Apache Spark
big data, written in Scala

LLM4S is open source too, under the MIT licence: free to use, free to join.

Why your portfolio matters more than a certificate

A degree

says you studied

A certificate

says you finished a course

A portfolio

shows what you can do, and anyone can check it

WHAT AN OPEN-SOURCE PORTFOLIO PROVES

- You can work on real software, not just a class project
- You can take feedback and improve
- You can collaborate with a team across time zones
- You ship: your work is in a public release

EXAMPLE RESUME LINE

Open-source contributor, LLM4S Foundation

Built a feature for an open-source AI project; reviewed by senior engineers and shipped in a public release.

`github.com/llm4s/llm4s/pull/…`

Open source beats an expensive bootcamp

	A PAID BOOTCAMP	OPEN SOURCE WITH LLM4S
COST	Course fees	Free: we don't charge anything. Google Summer of Code even pays a stipend
WHAT YOU BUILD	Capstone projects for a grade	Real software people use, shipped in 36 releases
WHO GUIDES YOU	Instructors on a fixed syllabus	Working engineers who check your work and reply fast
ON YOUR RESUME	A course certificate	Real-world experience: contributor to a real AI project, with work anyone can verify
YOUR NETWORK	One cohort	A global community of 400+ across time zones
STRUCTURE	A set curriculum and schedule	You pick the problems, and mentors help you scope them

Open source asks for initiative. In return it gives you real work, real reviewers and a public record of both.

Not one exhausted maintainer. A whole team.

MOST OPEN-SOURCE PROJECTS

60%

of maintainers are unpaid

60%

have quit or considered quitting

Often one tired maintainer carries the whole load, and newcomers wait.

Tidelift open source maintainer survey, 2024 (two years ago)

Senior mentors

Frequent calls with mentors and maintainers, online weekly and in person, like today.

Pair programming

Two people, one screen. Every Sunday at Dev Hour, code with people worldwide.

A buddy mentor

Someone is assigned to onboard you fast, so you are never stuck on day one.

Remote and global

50 mentors in 12 countries and 15 local chapters: build global connections from Delhi.

Fast reviews

539 changes accepted in the 30 days to 21 Oct 2026. Nobody waits weeks.

Free, and non-profit

We don't charge anything. What you gain is real experience, on your resume.

Your local chapter leads: 15 cities, 9 countries



Chapter leads organise local events and lead the LLM4S community in their city · Source: llm4s.org/people

How a real engineering team works, in the open

IN A COMPANY	IN LLM4S, WHERE YOU CAN WATCH AND JOIN
A stand-up or scrum call: a short team check-in	Sunday Dev Hour: we pick what to build, then code it together
A task board: who is doing what	GitHub issues and project boards
A senior checks work before it goes live	Every pull request is reviewed by a maintainer
Automatic quality checks	Automated tests check every change before it is accepted
Plans before big changes	17 design documents for large changes
Regular releases	36 releases, each with notes on what changed

Your path: from first issue to the global stage

STEP 1

Join the Discord

Say hello, ask anything

STEP 2

Watch Dev Hour

Sundays at 14:30 IST

STEP 3

First change

A beginner task, labelled for you

STEP 4

Own a feature

Scope it with a maintainer

STEP 5

Mentorship

Paired with an experienced mentor

STEP 6

Write and speak

Blogs, talks, conferences

50 **mentors**

engineers and researchers in 12 countries

India, the US, the UK, across Europe, Singapore and Ethiopia

IT HAPPENS

Shubham Vishwakarma built a real part of LLM4S with a mentor in 2025, then co-presented LLM4S at Oaisys 2025, an AI conference in Pune. Today he leads our Mumbai chapter.

It started with one commit

In January 2025, most LLM work happened in Python.

Teams building in Scala and Java had no reliable AI toolkit.

So the first commit did the smallest useful thing: ask an AI a question from Scala.

Everything since has grown from that one call.

```
$ git log --reverse

2025-01-29  Rory Graves
    Initial commit

2025-01-29  Rory Graves
    Initial base code calling an llm

2025-02-04  Rory Graves
    Update README.md

... 1,761 more
```

Source: git history of github.com/llm4s/llm4s, 1,764 commits as of 21 Oct 2026

From one call to 1.0, in public

JAN 2025
First commit: code that asks an AI a question

FEB 2025
First talk, in San Francisco

APR 2025
First release anyone can download

MAY 2025
Four Google Summer of Code students join

JUL 2025
Weekly Dev Hour begins

AUG 2025
Szork live on stage in Switzerland

DEC 2025
Answers questions from your own documents

FEB 2026
A big reliability upgrade

OCT 2026
Rebuilt into smaller, plug-in parts

NEXT
Version 1.0: a promise of stability

Sources: CHANGELOG.md and git history of github.com/llm4s/llm4s; talks archive in the LLM4S README

Twenty-one months, by the numbers

1,764
commits
since 29 Jan 2025

36
releases
v0.1.0 to v0.5.1

70+
code contributors
with commits on main

200+
contributors
across the community

400+
community members
and growing

14
talks
2025 to 2026, before today

7
countries
across three continents

4
GSoC contributors
Google Summer of Code 2025

Sources: git history and CHANGELOG.md of github.com/llm4s/llm4s, read 21 Oct 2026; talks archive in the README; contributor and member counts from the LLM4S Foundation

Szork: the demo that made it click



Scala Days 2025, SwissTech Convention Center, EPFL, Lausanne

A voice-controlled text adventure that reimagines Zork. An LLM4S agent runs the game as its Dungeon Master.

- **Agent as Dungeon Master** · story, world and inventory
- **Speak your moves** · speech-to-text
- **Narrated aloud** · text-to-speech
- **Illustrated scenes** · AI art for every new location

WATCH THE TALK

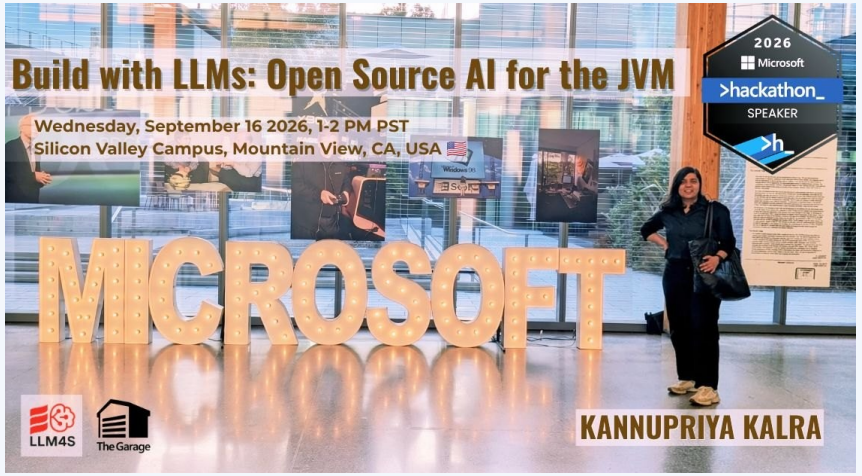
Scala Days 2025, Lausanne

youtube.com/watch?v=5od95FbNjiI

14 talks in 7 countries, before today

4	**United States**	San Francisco: Bay Area Scala · Dallas Scala Enthusiasts · San Jose: AI Compute & Hardware · Mountain View: Microsoft Global Hackathon
3	**Switzerland**	Lausanne: Scala Days and Scala Center lightning talks · Zürich Scala Enthusiasts
2	**United Kingdom**	London Scala Users Group · GenAI London
2	**India**	Scala India · Oaisys AI Practitioners Conference, Pune
1	**Poland**	Functional World, Gdańsk
1	**Germany**	Google Summer of Code Mentor Summit, Munich
1	**Singapore**	ICFP/SPLASH, Scala Workshop

NEXT LLM4S 1.0 talks · Singapore, 17 Nov · London, 25 and 26 Nov





Microsoft Global Hackathon, Mountain View, Sep 2026 (top); London Scala Users Group, Aug 2025

Five lessons for anyone building in public

01	**Ship the smallest thing that works.**	Our first commit asked an AI one question. Everything else came later.
02	**Make it weekly.**	Dev Hour has been on every Sunday since July 2025. A fixed slot gives newcomers a standing way in.
03	**Tell the story in public.**	Fourteen talks in seven countries, each one in front of people who had never heard of us.
04	**Mentor, and you multiply.**	Four students, each with a mentor, built big parts of LLM4S in a single summer.
05	**Clean up before you promise.**	Fix your foundations before people depend on you, like repairing a house before guests move in.

Start this week

Star the repo

Follow releases, read the code, open an issue.



github.com/llm4s/llm4s

Join the Discord

Ask anything, find a first issue, meet the maintainers.



discord.gg/4uvTPn6qww

Join Dev Hour

Live on Discord. Watch first, then drive.

Sundays 14:30 IST

09:00 London

Try it

Start with the beginner guide on llm4s.org.



llm4s.org

Students: LLM4S has mentored through Google Summer of Code. The next mentorship rounds are announced on Discord.

Building an AI non-profit is building a startup

IN A STARTUP	AT LLM4S
Build an MVP: the smallest version that works	First commit, January 2025: one call to an AI
Build in public and get feedback early	All work on GitHub, and live every Sunday at Dev Hour
Raise funding	Google funded paid student contributors through Summer of Code
Hire a team	50 mentors and 15 chapter leads in 9 countries
Market it	14 talks in 7 countries, before today
Ship, listen, improve	36 releases in 18 months

Open source first, startup later

2009 → 2013

Apache Spark → Databricks

A UC Berkeley research project, open-sourced in 2010. Its creators founded Databricks in 2013.

LinkedIn → 2014

Apache Kafka → Confluent

Built by engineers at LinkedIn, who founded Confluent in 2014. It filed to go public in 2021.

2011 → 2014

GitLab → GitLab Inc.

One developer's project, built at home in Ukraine. A company in 2014, then Y Combinator, then NASDAQ in 2021.

2009 → 2012

Elasticsearch → Elastic

Started by one developer in 2009. The company followed in 2012 and listed in New York in 2018.

Oct 2022 → 2023

LangChain → a company

An open-source AI library that became a funded company, LangChain Inc., within about six months.

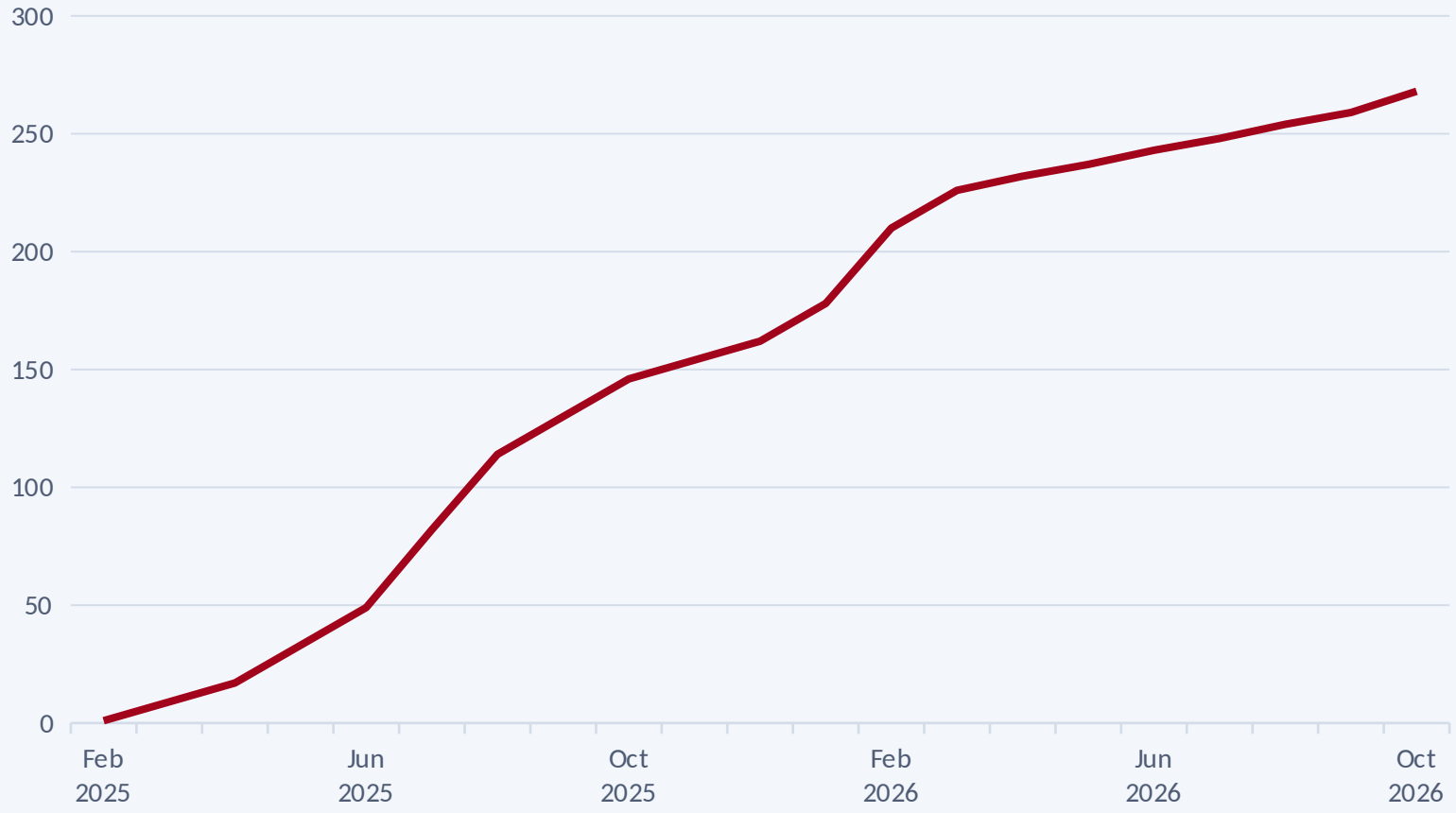
2004 → 2011

Scala → Typesafe

Martin Odersky's language led him to co-found Typesafe (now Lightbend) in 2011. LLM4S is built in Scala.

THE PATTERN Build something useful in the open. Earn users and trust. Then build the business.

Traction: slow, then steady



About 270

GitHub stars (like bookmarks) by October 2026, from 1 in February 2025

Jun to Aug 2025

The steepest climb, 49 to 114: GSoC, the London Scala talk and Scala Days

Jan to Feb 2026

Another step, 178 to 210, around a major release

Approximate monthly values, read from the star-history chart in the LLM4S README on 21 Oct 2026

Test your startup idea in open source

Real users, early

People around the world tell you what they actually need, before you spend a rupee.

A global network

50 mentors and 15 chapters: future co-founders, advisors and first customers.

Skills that compound

AI, teamwork, shipping, writing and speaking, while you are still a student.

Funding pathways

Programmes like Google Summer of Code pay contributors; a public track record helps with grants and investors.

Credibility

A public record of what you built, who reviewed it and who uses it.

Low risk

Free, no office, no fees. Test the waters before you quit anything.

FOR TODAY'S PITCHES Show the smallest version that works, proof that real people want it, and the team behind it.

LLM4S

Thank you, VIPS-TC!

Questions?

Good luck to every team at Pitch Please.

EMAIL kannupriya@llm4s.org

LINKEDIN linkedin.com/in/kannupriyakalra

WEB llm4s.org

LINKEDIN GITHUB

